

DEPARTMENT POLICY

This item applies to **Food Assistance Program (FAP)** benefits **only**. FAP groups consisting entirely of Social Security Income (SSI) applicants or recipients may choose to apply for FAP benefits at the Social Security Administration (SSA) office. This includes individuals who apply for SSI and FAP benefits before being released from medical institutions. Whenever an SSI individual contacts the SSA office for any business, SSA will advise the individual of the right to apply for FAP benefits at the SSA office. SSI individuals retain the option of applying for FAP benefits at an Michigan Department Health Human Services (MDHHS) office.

The MDHHS-1171, Assistance Application, and the 1171-FAP, Supplement-FAP are used for SSI individuals choosing to apply for FAP at the SSA office. SSA screens the MDHHS-1171 for potential entitlement to expedited service and informs the applicant that they may receive benefits sooner if they apply at an MDHHS office.

SSI individuals may also complete the redetermination process at the SSA office. All FAP redetermination policies in [Bridges Administrative Manual \(BAM\) 210](#), Redetermination/Ex Parte Review, apply **except** the in-person interview must be waived if requested by an SSI group **and** the group is unable to appoint an authorized representative. SSA will handle the application in the same manner as an initial application but will indicate in red at the top of the MDHHS-1171 that it is a redetermination.

Individual Rights and Responsibilities

SSI groups are entitled to the same rights and have the same responsibilities as any other FAP group.

SSA Responsibilities

When an SSI group chooses to apply for FAP through SSA, they will take the following actions:

- Assist the individual in completing the FAP application.
- Prescreen each application for entitlement to expedited service and mark "Expedited Processing" on the first page of all applications which seem to require it.

- Interview with the applicant.
- Attach a transmittal form to all applications regarding verification(s). See *Verification Provided by SSA* in this item.
- Forward applications to the designated local office within one working day after receiving receipt.
- Give the applicant the local office pamphlet (or loose materials) which provides basic program information, issuance information, and instructions for obtaining FAP. SSA orders these materials through the local office.
- Give the applicant information on how and where to receive Electronic Benefit Transfer (EBT) training. Food Assistance benefits issued in the form of EBT are accessed using a plastic Bridge Card. Individuals must be aware of what is required of them if they don't go into the local office.

Local offices should arrange with their local SSA office for the most convenient and timely method for transmitting applications.

Local Office Responsibilities

Upon receipt of a signed application from SSA, the local office must take the following actions:

- Register the application if the individual has **not** already applied for or been approved for FAP benefits. Use the date filed at SSA for the application date.
- Process applications according to the appropriate standard of promptness, based on the date they were filed at the SSA office. (See *Exception below*.)
- Bridges automatically screens **all** applications for expedited service. The expedited service timeliness standard begins on the date after the application was received at an MDHHS office; see *Exception* in this item.

Exception: Individuals may apply for SSI and FAP benefits before being released from medical institutions. The application filing date for these applications is the date of release from the institution.

Example:

Application completed	10/10/08
Date of Release	10/10/08
SOP: (expedited FAP)	10/17/08
(non-expedited)	11/9/08

Interviews

Since SSA conducts the interview, the local office is **not** required to reinterview the applicant. The MDHHS specialist must **not** contact the group unless:

- The application is improperly completed.
- Mandatory verification is missing.
- Certain information on the application is questionable.

If the specialist contacts the SSI/FAP group for one of the above reasons, the specialist **cannot** require the group to come to the local office or discuss items which are unrelated to the reason for the contact.

Verification Provided by SSA

All mandatory verifications must be obtained prior to approving eligibility. Verification may be provided by SSA via the SSA-4233, Social Security Administration Transmittal for FAP Applications, or through the usual means of verification.

SSA will provide all verification available at application. The transmittal form will indicate one of three things regarding each item requiring mandatory verification.

- **Verified.** The verification or a photocopy will be attached.
- **In SSI File.** The item is verified, but the document was retained in the SSI file. This statement from SSA is acceptable verification for FAP purposes.
- **Not Verified.** Verification was **not** available to SSA and must be obtained by the MDHHS specialist.

In addition, the SSA workers will indicate areas which are questionable on the back of the transmittal form. The SSA workers will verify these areas if the verification is available at application.

If a group returns needed verification to SSA rather than an MDHHS office, SSA will forward it using an SSA-4233 marked “Evidence Only.”

Verification **not** provided through SSA must be provided by the group or obtained through automated system matches. The match from SSA may be used to verify SSI status and benefit amount. If the match indicates earned income, it **cannot** be used to verify the earned income. Also, the FAP group must be given the opportunity to provide verification from another source if the information from SSA contradicts other group information.

Do **not** delay processing the application while waiting for the HR-070 or BENDEX report.

Eligibility Factors

SSI/FAP groups must meet all FAP non-financial and financial eligibility factors listed in the Bridges Eligibility Manual (BEM).

Benefit Periods

Assign a benefit period according to the guidelines in [BAM 115, Application Processing](#), Benefit Periods.

CHANGES

SSI/FAP groups must report changes within 10 days. See [BAM 105, Rights and Responsibilities](#), Responsibility to Report Changes. The FAP group will receive information from MDHHS if their reporting requirements are different.

Complete any necessary budget changes in Bridges upon learning of the SSI determination. If the information is discovered and it appears that the FAP group did **not** report receipt of SSI benefits within 10 days of receipt of first payment as required, an overissuance may have occurred. Handle the overissuance according to policy in [BAM 700, Benefit Overpayments](#), and [BAM 720, Intentional Program Violation](#).

LEGAL BASE

FAP

7 CFR 273.2(k)
7 CFR 273.12
7 CFR 274.2